



Waypoint

FREE TRIP PLANNER

The Complete Namibia Self- Drive Guide

History, facts, the route mapped out, roads, fuel, animals, campsites, packing, contacts, and everything else I wish someone had told me before ten days behind the wheel.

By José Maria Garcia · Waypoint

What's Inside

This guide is organized so you can jump straight to what you need — read it cover to cover before you go, or keep it open on your phone while you're on the road.

01	Namibia at a Glance	Page 3
02	Your Route, Mapped	Page 4
03	The Route & Booking Timeline	Page 5
04	Roads, the Vehicle & Fuel Planning	Page 6
05	Safety: Animals, Roads & the Car Emergency Kit	Page 7
06	What to Pack & How to Pack It	Page 8
07	Offline Apps & Grocery Shopping Strategy	Page 9
08	The Car Shopping List: Food, Paper & Firewood	Page 10
09	Car Rental Companies	Page 11
10	Windhoek: Hotels, Supermarkets & Phone Numbers	Page 12
11	Etosha in Depth: Gates, Camps & Watching Animals	Page 13
12	Etosha Wildlife Spotter's List & Photography Tips	Page 14
13	A Small Story	Page 15
14	What to Expect From Namibian Campsites	Page 16
15	Damaraland Highlights & Meeting the Himba	Page 17
16	Traveler FAQ	Page 18
17	Final Checklist Recap	Page 19

Before anything else

Read the full trip report at hellowaypoint.com/articles/namibia-solo-road-trip.html for the narrative version of this same journey, and the complete Namibia country guide at hellowaypoint.com/countries/namibia.html for budget, visa, and food details not repeated here.

01 • Namibia at a Glance

CAPITAL	Windhoek
POPULATION	Around 2.6 million — one of the lowest population densities of any country on Earth
LANGUAGES	English (official), alongside German, Afrikaans, Oshiwambo, Otjiherero, and other local languages
CURRENCY	Namibian dollar, pegged 1:1 to and used interchangeably with the South African rand
LANDSCAPE	Home to the Namib, believed to be the world's oldest desert at roughly 55 million years old; the fog-bound Skeleton Coast; and Fish River Canyon, the second-largest canyon in the world

A short history

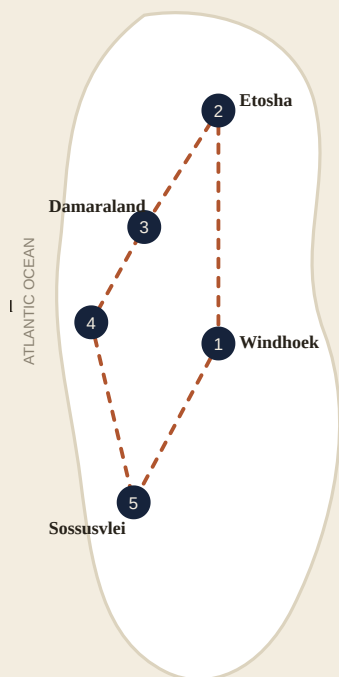
Namibia's human history stretches back tens of thousands of years to the San people, among the oldest continuous cultures on Earth, whose rock art still marks sites like Twyfelfontein today. Over the centuries that followed, the Nama, Herero, Himba, Owambo, and other peoples settled the region's very different landscapes, from the northern floodplains to the arid south.

German colonial rule began in 1884, establishing the territory then known as German South West Africa. That period included a brutal campaign against the Herero and Nama peoples between 1904 and 1908, now widely recognized as a genocide — a history that remains present in the country's memory and politics today. After Germany's defeat in the First World War, South Africa took over administration of the territory and, over time, extended its own apartheid-era racial policies to it. A long independence struggle led by SWAPO culminated in Namibia becoming, in 1990, the last African country to gain independence from colonial and settler rule.

Today Namibia is a stable, multi-party democracy — and, notably, the first country in the world to write environmental protection directly into its constitution, a commitment visible in just how well the parks and wildlife here are managed.

02 • Your Route, Mapped

A schematic (not-to-scale) view of the ten-day loop, starting and ending in Windhoek.



- 1 **Windhoek** — start and finish, collect the vehicle here
- 2 **Etosha** — three nights of waterhole game viewing
- 3 **Damaraland** — Brandberg, Twyfelfontein, Spitzkoppe
- 4 **Swakopmund** — coastal town, Sandwich Harbour day trip
- 5 **Sossusvlei** — sunrise on the dunes, then back to Windhoek

Schematic route diagram, not to scale. Actual driving distances are considerably longer than the map suggests — see the road notes on page 6.

03 · The Route & Booking Timeline

DAYS	STOP	WHAT IT'S FOR
1	Windhoek → Etosha	Arrival, collect the vehicle, drive north (~4.5h)
2–4	Etosha National Park	Waterhole game viewing, floodlit camp at night
5	Etosha → Opuwo → Damaraland	Long transit day, scenery shifts to rugged desert-mountain
6	Damaraland	Brandberg rock art, Twyfelfontein, Spitzkoppe at sunset
7	Damaraland → Swakopmund	Coastal town, real beds, real coffee
8	Swakopmund (Sandwich Harbour day trip)	Flamingos, seals, dunes-into-ocean, beach lunch
9	Swakopmund → Namib Desert	Head south to a desert camp near Sossusvlei's gate
10	Sossusvlei & Deadvlei → Windhoek	Sunrise on the dunes, then the long drive back

Book this far ahead

Namibia's popularity in dry season (May–October) means the good spots go early.

6+ months ahead

Etosha park campsites via Namibia Wildlife Resorts (NWR) — especially Okaukuejo for the floodlit waterhole.

Rooftop-tent 4x4 rental — good vehicles sell out first.

1–2 months ahead

Private campsites and lodges in Damaraland, Swakopmund, and near Sossusvlei.

Your Sandwich Harbour day tour (GetYourGuide or similar) — popular slots fill fast.

04 · Roads, the Vehicle & Fuel Planning

Understanding Namibia's road grades

B-roads are tarred and behave like normal highways. **C-roads** are the backbone of most self-drive routes — well-graded gravel, fine at 80–100 km/h in good conditions, but corrugated stretches and sudden sandy patches are common. **D-roads** are minor gravel tracks, often narrower and rougher, sometimes requiring genuine 4x4 clearance after rain. Slow down for all of them more than instinct suggests — gravel hides ruts, and a rolled vehicle is the single most common serious incident for self-drivers here.

Driving realities worth knowing before you go

- ☐ Corrugations (repetitive ripples) are hardest on tires and nerves alike — easing off speed slightly, or occasionally speeding up to "float" over them, both work depending on the surface; test cautiously
- ☐ Avoid driving after dark outside of towns wherever possible — wildlife on the road is a real risk and gravel hazards are far harder to see
- ☐ Distances feel short on the map and long in the car — a "200km" stretch of gravel can easily take 3 hours
- ☐ River crossings after rain (rare but possible in the wet season) should never be attempted if the water's depth or current is unclear

Fuel planning

Fuel stations are reliable in towns (Windhoek, Otjiwarongo, Outjo, Khorixas, Swakopmund, Walvis Bay, Solitaire) but genuinely sparse between them. Treat "half a tank" as your trigger to refuel, not "empty." A few specific gaps worth flagging: the stretch between Sesriem and Solitaire has only one small station, often the only fuel for a wide radius, and remote Damaraland routes can go 150km+ without one. Carry a full plastic jerry can as backup if your rental offers one — most do.

05 · Safety: Animals, Roads & the Car Emergency Kit

Animal-related risks

- ☐ Kudu and other antelope crossing roads at dawn/dusk are a genuine collision risk — slow down specifically in the first and last hour of daylight
- ☐ Inside parks: never exit the vehicle outside of designated rest camps or marked viewpoints, even if an animal looks distant or calm
- ☐ Elephants can appear on open roads in Damaraland and near park boundaries — give them generous space and never drive between a mother and calf
- ☐ Snakes are rarely encountered but do exist — watch where you step at night around camp, and shake out shoes left outside overnight

Other practical risks

- ☐ Heat and dehydration sneak up fast in the desert regions — drink more water than feels necessary, even on cooler-feeling days
- ☐ Sun exposure is intense at altitude and in open desert — reapply sunscreen more often than at home
- ☐ Tire punctures are common on gravel — knowing how to change a tire yourself is genuinely important here
- ☐ Cell signal disappears for long stretches — tell someone your rough daily plan before you lose it

What to carry in the car at all times

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Two full-size spare tires (not one) | ☐ Extra 5–10L water beyond drinking supply |
| ☐ Tire repair kit and a 12V compressor pump | ☐ Full jerry can of fuel as backup |
| ☐ Jack and wheel wrench, tested before you leave the depot | ☐ Basic first-aid kit |
| ☐ Tow rope or strap | ☐ Paper road map as backup to offline apps |

If you break down

Stay with the vehicle rather than walking for help — it's easier for other travelers or rangers to spot a car than a person on foot, and distances between help are often greater than they appear.

06 · What to Pack & How to Pack It

Clothing (layers matter more than volume)

Namibia swings from hot, dusty days to genuinely cold desert nights and early mornings — pack for both, not just the daytime heat.

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| ☐ Lightweight, breathable shirts (neutral colors hide dust better) | ☐ Sturdy closed shoes for rocky terrain | ☐ Swimwear (coastal stops, some lodge pools) |
| ☐ One warm fleece or jacket for dawn game drives | ☐ Sandals for camp evenings | ☐ One smarter outfit if any lodge dinners are planned |
| ☐ A buff or scarf for dust on gravel roads | ☐ Wide-brimmed hat and sunglasses | ☐ Warm sleepwear for rooftop-tent nights |

Gear beyond clothing

- ☐ Headlamp or torch (essential for the rooftop tent ladder after dark)
- ☐ Power bank and a universal adapter (Namibia uses Type D/M plugs)
- ☐ Binoculars — genuinely upgrades every waterhole and game drive
- ☐ Dry bags or packing cubes to keep dust out of clean clothes
- ☐ Reusable water bottles, at least 1.5L capacity per person
- ☐ High-SPF sunscreen and insect repellent

How to actually pack the vehicle

Soft duffel bags compress into odd spaces far better than hard suitcases. Keep one "daily access" bag (sunscreen, snacks, camera, documents) within reach of the front seats. Store food separately and sealed, since dust and occasional curious wildlife around camps both find loose food.

07 · Offline Apps & Grocery Shopping Strategy

Download before you leave Windhoek

- ☐ **Maps.me** — download the Namibia region; reliable offline turn-by-turn on gravel

- ☐ **Tracks4Africa** — GPS maps built specifically for African road conditions

- ☐ **Google Maps** offline areas — useful backup, mainly reliable for towns

- ☐ A local SIM card (MTC is the main network) for connectivity in towns — coverage disappears completely between them

Where to stock up along the way

Windhoek has the best-stocked supermarkets on the route — your one real chance to shop properly before heading into remote territory (see page 12 for specific locations). Otjiwarongo and Outjo, en route to Etosha, have decent shops for fresh top-ups. Swakopmund has full supermarkets, a good moment to restock before the desert leg south. Remote stretches (Damaraland, the Namib) have only small, limited general stores at best.

08 · The Car Shopping List: Food, Paper & Firewood

Pantry staples for ten days

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Bread, oats, or cereal for breakfast | ☐ Pasta or rice plus jarred sauce for simple dinners |
| ☐ UHT milk (doesn't need refrigeration until opened) | ☐ Fresh braai meat bought a day or two ahead, kept cold |
| ☐ Coffee, tea, and instant options for early starts | ☐ Biltong, nuts, and dried fruit — heat-stable snacks |
| ☐ Crackers, cheese, canned tuna or beans for easy lunches | ☐ Bottled water beyond what feels necessary |
| ☐ Fresh fruit that travels well — apples, oranges | ☐ A treat or two — morale matters on long driving days |

Paper goods & cleaning

- ☐ Toilet paper — bring more than you think; campsite shops don't always stock it
- ☐ Paper towels and a roll of wet wipes (invaluable when water is limited)
- ☐ Black trash bags — pack out what you pack in at remote sites
- ☐ Small dish soap bottle and a sponge
- ☐ Matches or a lighter, kept dry

Cooking gear & firewood

Most rooftop-tent rentals already include a gas stove, cooler or fridge, pots, plates, and cutlery — confirm this specifically when booking rather than assuming it's included. You rarely need to bring your own firewood or charcoal: it's sold at petrol stations, campsite shops, and by roadside vendors near towns, and most NWR camps and private sites sell bundles on-site. Grab extra if you know you'll arrive at a remote site after the shop closes for the day.

09 • Car Rental Companies

A handful of established options for a fully kitted rooftop-tent 4x4 — compare insurance excess, included kilometers, and exactly what camping gear is bundled, since these vary more between companies than price does.

- ☐ **Drive South Africa** — a well-known booking platform covering multiple local operators; straightforward for first-time bookers coordinating from abroad
- ☐ **Bushlore** — an established regional operator with fully kitted rooftop-tent 4x4s across Southern Africa
- ☐ **Britz** — one of the larger, most recognized self-drive rental brands in the region
- ☐ **Drive Namibia** — a smaller, Namibia-based, family-run operator frequently praised for personal service
- ☐ **Namibia2Go / local Namibian agents** — often more affordable, with strong local knowledge of current road conditions

Before you book

Read recent reviews for your specific chosen operator rather than relying on brand name alone — service quality in this space can vary year to year. Confirm in writing: two spare tires, unlimited kilometers, and exactly which camping equipment (fridge, stove, tables, bedding) is included.

10 · Windhoek: Hotels, Supermarkets & Phone Numbers

Where to stay for a night on either end of the trip

- ☐ **Hilton Windhoek** , Rev. Michael Scott Street — central, reliable, upscale; a comfortable first or last night
- ☐ **Arebbusch Travel Lodge** , corner of Auas and Golf Street — relaxed, self-drive-friendly lodge with a pool, popular with overlanders near the airport road

Where to stock up before heading out

- ☐ **Maerua Mall** , corner of Jan Jonker Street & Centaurus Road — Checkers and Food Lovers Market, one of the most convenient stops
- ☐ **Wernhil Park** , Windhoek CBD — Pick n Pay and Checkers, central location
- ☐ **Grove Mall** , Chasie Street, Kleine Kuppe — Checkers, Spar, and Woolworths; the country's largest shopping centre

Useful phone numbers

- ☐ Police (nationwide): 10111
- ☐ General emergency (mobile networks): 112
- ☐ E-Med Rescue 24 (private ambulance): 924 (toll-free) or +264 61 411 600
- ☐ Windhoek municipal emergency services: +264 61 211 111

Before you leave Windhoek

Save your car rental company's emergency line and your travel insurance's assistance number in your phone. In a genuine emergency, they're often faster and more useful than a generic number — always confirm current numbers, as they can change.

11 · Etosha in Depth

The three main gates

- ☐ **Andersson Gate** (south) — the main entrance, closest to Windhoek, leads directly to Okaukuejo camp
- ☐ **Von Lindequist Gate** (east) — closest to Namutoni camp, convenient from the northeast
- ☐ **King Nehale Gate** (north) — the newest gate, useful from the Ovamboland region

How to actually see the animals

Etosha rewards patience over distance covered. Pick a waterhole, park with your engine off, and wait — twenty minutes of stillness often beats two hours of driving between sightings. Early morning and late afternoon are the most active periods; midday heat sends most wildlife into shade. Floodlit waterholes at the rest camps (Okaukuejo's is the most famous) turn every evening into a viewing opportunity without leaving camp.

Main camps inside the park

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Okaukuejo — famous floodlit waterhole, near Andersson Gate | ☐ Dolomite Camp — more remote, western section |
| ☐ Halali — central location, own floodlit waterhole | ☐ Onkoshi — small, exclusive, on the edge of the pan |
| ☐ Namutoni — a restored German-era fort | |

If NWR's in-park camps are sold out, private lodges near each gate offer comparable access with more amenities, usually at a higher price, while still allowing an early gate entry for the best light and activity.

12 · Etosha Wildlife Spotter's List & Photography Tips

Predators & big cats

- ☐ **Lion** — prides often rest near waterholes by day and hunt at dusk
- ☐ **Leopard** — elusive and mostly nocturnal; a genuine prize sighting
- ☐ **Cheetah** — Etosha holds one of Africa's healthiest wild cheetah populations
- ☐ **Spotted hyena** — often heard before seen, with an unmistakable whooping call at night
- ☐ **Black-backed jackal** — Etosha's most commonly spotted small predator

Giants & grazers

- ☐ **African elephant** — look for the pale, dusty color from Etosha's white calcrete soil
- ☐ **Black rhino** — critically endangered; Etosha is one of the best places on Earth to see one wild
- ☐ **Giraffe** — Etosha's are the Angolan subspecies, with distinctly patterned coats
- ☐ **Burchell's zebra** — travels in large, noisy herds across the open plains
- ☐ **Gemsbok (oryx)** — Namibia's national animal, with rapier-straight horns
- ☐ **Greater kudu** — spiral horns, famously good at vanishing into thin bush
- ☐ **Springbok** — named for "pronking," its stiff-legged leap into the air

Birds worth knowing

- ☐ **Kori bustard** — the heaviest flying bird in the world
- ☐ **Secretary bird** — a long-legged raptor that hunts snakes on foot
- ☐ **Lilac-breasted roller** — arguably the most photogenic bird in southern Africa

Photography tips

Bring the longest zoom you own — you can't get closer, and shouldn't try. Shoot in the first and last two hours of daylight for the best light and the most active animals. Rest the camera on a beanbag or rolled towel on the window frame for steadier shots during long waits. Turn off flash entirely at night waterholes. Bring a spare battery — cold desert mornings drain them fast. Keep the engine off and stay quiet; sound travels far across open plains.

The Night the Lions Came to Drink

It was our third and final night at Okaukuejo, and I'd nearly talked myself out of going back to the waterhole — two good evenings already behind us, and the rooftop tent was tempting in the growing chill. I went anyway, mostly out of habit.

For the first half hour, nothing much. A single black-backed jackal trotted through the floodlight and vanished again. A couple of springbok drank cautiously, heads snapping up between sips. Then, without any warning I noticed, the springbok simply weren't there anymore — gone, silent, into the dark beyond the light.

A few minutes later I understood why. Four lionesses walked into the floodlit circle like they owned it, which, this being Etosha, they more or less did. They didn't rush. They drank unhurried, occasionally glancing up at the small, quiet crowd of us gathered along the low wall, as if we were the mildly interesting ones for once. One of them lay down afterward, right at the water's edge, and simply stayed there for the better part of an hour while the rest of us barely breathed.

I've watched lions from a vehicle before, at a comfortable, managed distance. This was different — no engine, no barrier beyond a low stone wall, nothing between us but a floodlight and their evident indifference to our presence. I went to bed that night thinking that was, without much competition, the best hour of the entire trip.

14 · What to Expect From Namibian Campsites

Facilities vary widely, but most self-drive campsites share a similar basic structure.

What's usually included

- ☐ A demarcated pitch with a braai (barbecue) pit — bring your own charcoal or firewood, sometimes sold on-site
- ☐ Shared ablution blocks with hot showers (quality varies; NWR camps are functional but basic, private camps often nicer)
- ☐ A small on-site shop for basics — ice, drinks, snacks — not a substitute for proper grocery shopping
- ☐ Some form of perimeter fencing at most rest camps, though unfenced private sites do exist, particularly in Damaraland

Good habits at camp

- ☐ Never leave food unsealed or unattended, even inside a closed tent
- ☐ Check with staff whether the specific site is fenced before assuming it is
- ☐ Arrive with enough daylight to set up the rooftop tent comfortably
- ☐ Expect genuinely dark skies and quiet nights — one of the best parts of the trip, not a compromise

A tip that made a real difference

At Okaukuejo, skip the evening game drive and just sit at the floodlit waterhole after dinner instead. Rhinos in particular tend to move at night — it cost nothing extra and delivered the best hour of the whole trip.

15 · Damaraland Highlights & Meeting the Himba

Damaraland's main stops

- ☐ **Brandberg Mountain** — Namibia's highest peak, home to the "White Lady" rock painting; a local guide is required and worth it
- ☐ **Twyfelfontein** — a UNESCO World Heritage site with thousands of ancient San rock engravings
- ☐ **Petrified Forest** — fossilized tree trunks over 280 million years old, an easy stop en route
- ☐ **Organ Pipes & Burnt Mountain** — striking volcanic rock formations near Twyfelfontein
- ☐ **Desert-adapted elephants** — found along the dry riverbeds; guided trackers improve the odds
- ☐ **Spitzkoppe** — dramatic granite peaks, best visited near sunset

Meeting the Himba: how to get there, and which visit to choose

The Kunene region around Opuwo is home to the Himba, an indigenous people known for their distinctive ochre-covered skin and hair and a semi-nomadic pastoral way of life largely unchanged for generations. It's reached via gravel roads (the C41/C43) from Damaraland, or directly from Etosha's western side — expect a half-day of rougher gravel driving, so factor this into your transit day.

Independent, unannounced stops at roadside Himba settlements are best avoided — they tend to be uncomfortable for the community, or staged specifically (and unremarkably) for passing tourists. The better option is a visit arranged through your accommodation in or near Opuwo: most lodges there run or can connect you with genuine, community-consenting cultural visits that include a translator guide. This ensures the community is properly informed and fairly compensated, and that the exchange feels less transactional for everyone involved.

- ☐ Ask before photographing anyone, and expect a small payment or craftwork purchase is customary in exchange for a visit
- ☐ Treat it as an exchange, not a spectacle — a guide who can facilitate real conversation makes it far more meaningful for everyone

16 • Traveler FAQ

Do I need a visa for Namibia?

Requirements vary by nationality and do change — check the current rules for your passport well before booking flights.

Is Namibia safe for solo travelers?

Generally yes — it's one of the more stable, low-crime countries in the region, though normal precautions apply, especially in city centers at night.

Do I really need a 4x4?

For this route, yes. Damaraland, remote Etosha camps, and parts of the route to Sossusvlei sit on gravel or sand roads where a standard sedan isn't practical, and most rental companies won't permit it anyway.

Is tap water safe to drink?

Tap water in Windhoek and most larger towns is treated and generally safe. Bottled or filtered water is the safer default in more remote areas and campsites.

Is malaria a risk on this route?

Some risk exists in the far northeast (Caprivi/Zambezi region), well outside this specific loop. Consult a travel clinic based on your exact itinerary and timing.

What currency should I carry?

Namibian dollars and South African rand are both accepted everywhere. Cards work in most towns, but carry cash for fuel stops, campsite fees, and small vendors in remote areas.

Can I drink alcohol at campsites?

Generally yes at private sites and lodges; policies vary inside national parks, so check each camp's specific rules.

What's the best time of year to go?

Dry season, roughly May to October, offers the most reliable wildlife viewing since animals cluster at waterholes, and generally easier driving conditions.

Will I have phone signal?

In towns, generally yes with a local SIM. Expect long stretches with none at all once you're on the open road between them.

17 · Final Checklist Recap

Before you leave home

- ☐ Vehicle and rooftop tent booked (6+ months ahead in dry season)
- ☐ Etosha park camps booked via NWR
- ☐ Sandwich Harbour excursion booked
- ☐ Offline map apps downloaded
- ☐ Travel insurance confirmed

In the car, always

- ☐ Two spare tires + repair kit
- ☐ Extra water and a fuel jerry can
- ☐ First-aid kit
- ☐ Paper backup of bookings and a road map
- ☐ Headlamp within reach

Want the full story?

Read the complete trip report at hellowaypoint.com/articles/namibia-solo-road-trip.html, or explore the full Namibia country guide — attractions, budget, and a suggested itinerary with map — at hellowaypoint.com/countries/namibia.html.